

Press Release — For immediate release

Date: 7 June 2026 **Contact:** Lisa Lynch, no2option7.org | info@no2option7.org

Irish Rail forced to revise depot road assessment as East Cork community mounts major campaign against Option 7

Carrigtwohill/Midleton, 7 June 2026 — Irish Rail has confirmed that it is revising its Multi-Criteria Assessment and depot access road design for the Cork Area Commuter Rail (CACR) maintenance facility at Ballyrichard, following overwhelming public opposition from the East Cork community. The revision follows weeks of organised pressure from residents, including formal objections, political lobbying, and the launch of a dedicated campaign website.

The controversy centres on Option 7 — the route selected by Roughan & O’Donovan Consulting Engineers on behalf of Irish Rail for a new access road to the CACR maintenance depot planned for Ballyrichard, near Carrigtwohill, across the tracks from the InterConnector that is on the IDA site. Of the eight routes assessed, Option 7 is the only one that permanently acquires residential garden land, and it scores Highly Negative — the worst possible rating — on Noise and Vibration, with nine homes within 100 metres of the proposed road. Some homes are within 10 metres.

Despite the revision, Option 7 has not been withdrawn. Irish Rail has given no date for when the revised assessment will be available, and the public consultation deadline remains **19 June 2026**.

Community turns out in force

A large group of residents and members of the public attended the PC2 public consultation meeting hosted by Roughan & O’Donovan in My Place in Midleton on May 27th, where attendees publicly and overwhelmingly opposed Option 7 directly to the project engineers. The campaign website, no2option7.org, has since been shared widely across East Cork, prompting many residents to submit formal objections to Irish Rail.

Political support for the campaign has come from **Liam Quaide TD**, who met with affected residents on 4 June and pledged his support, from **Mona Stromsoe of Aontú**, who met with residents on 23 May and also pledged support, and from **Cynthia Ni Mhurachu MEP**, who sent a formal letter to Irish Rail on 2 June requesting information on behalf of an affected resident.

A private road built at public expense — on a corridor already planned for a cycleway

Impacted resident Lisa Lynch said the community’s objection goes beyond the impact on individual homes.

“This is public money being spent on a private staff access road that will only ever be used by Irish Rail workers. Meanwhile, Cork County Council has spent years planning a traffic-free cycleway through the same agricultural corridor as part of the Carrigtwohill to Midleton Inter-Urban Cycleway Phase 2. Irish Rail’s own engineering drawings show Option 7 running directly alongside that cycle path, accommodating HGVs and Low Loaders going to and from the depot. If this goes ahead, East Cork loses both: residents lose their gardens, and the community loses the cycleway.”

Independent ecological surveys have also confirmed the presence of five Annex IV bat species and two Red-listed bird species — Yellowhammer and Snipe — in the hedgerows and agricultural land along the Option 7 corridor. Residents hold photographic evidence showing the route already floods under existing conditions, directly contradicting Irish Rail’s own Neutral flood risk rating for the option.

Better options exist

The campaign points to alternatives — including Option 4 — that would deliver a road with genuine public benefit. The N25 Carrigtwohill to Midleton Upgrade Scheme has not been allocated funding and has no confirmed delivery timeline. In the event of an eastbound incident on the N25, there is currently no viable alternative route for traffic. Option 4’s alignment could provide that alternative, delivering community benefit beyond the needs of the depot.

Online meeting — Tuesday 10 June

Irish Rail and Roughan & O’Donovan will host an online public meeting on **Tuesday 10 June, 7–8:30pm**. Residents can request the joining link by emailing CACR@irishrail.ie.

The formal consultation deadline is **19 June 2026**. Objections can be submitted to CACR@irishrail.ie. Full technical grounds of objection and further information are available at **no2option7.org**.

Ends

Notes to editor:

- The CACR Phase 2 Public Consultation No. 2 (PC2) is a non-statutory consultation. A Railway Order application to An Coimisiún Pleanála is expected to follow at the end of the year.
- The campaign website no2option7.org includes full technical grounds of objection with direct references to Irish Rail’s own consultation documents.
- High-resolution images and photographic evidence of flooding on the Option 7 route are available on request.
- Residents are available for interview and can be contacted at info@no2option7.org.
- A group photo of residents is planned for later this week.